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Janis Siegel

Janis Siegel has enjoyed a creative career as a solo jazz singer and as a member of Manhattan Transfer. She is a nine time Grammy award winner, and her collaborations include work with Jon Hendricks, Fred Hersch, Bobby McFerrin, and Take 6.

Janis was interviewed in Clinton, New York on May 22, 2015 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. I'm very pleased to have Janis Siegel here. Thanks for coming.

JS: I kind of had to.

MR: Well you did because it was in your contract.

JS: Yeah. And our last visit was aborted by a bomb scare.

MR: Yes. So we never did make it happen.

JS: No.

MR: I was thinking on the way up, I was reading up on you, you know, and the Manhattan Transfer and all that, and the success and the Grammys.

JS: The glamour.

MR: The glamour. And then that's what I was thinking. Even with the Grammys, you still get to clean up dorm rooms after your son.

JS: Yup. Oh it's frightening. It's so frightening.

MR: That's real life, right? When you were oh 17, 18, did you have aspirations to make it in the music business?

JS: That was really never my aspiration I would say. And at age 17 I was a nursing major at State University of New York at Buffalo. So I was planning on a whole nother course really, even though I had already been singing professionally for quite a while. But for some reason never really was counting on it as a serious course of action. I wasn't even a music major for God's sake. That was really stupid in retrospect. But I just wanted to sing. That was the drive.

MR: Okay. You didn't have pie-in-the-sky ideas about —

JS: No. I'm a worker bee.

MR: That's a good way to put it. And when did the idea that maybe I actually could make a living at this sort of gel?

JS: Well I did leave school to pursue singing. And even then I was prepared and happy to struggle and really I left school and started, or revigorated my girl group, then called

aide with handicapped children. And some were autistic and really responded to music. And that really kind of sparked me and brought together two great passions of mine, music and medicine. So that was very cool. And at night we would play. We would practice and one of the little girls was going to college, she was going to Harpur, and I just did what I could to scrape along. When I really — I think it was really when the Manhattan Transfer was starting that I thought hey this could really be something. But that was never really my focus.

MR: Okay. Well for not attending music school and all that formal training, you must have had a steep learning curve. Let me just play something here and ask you about —
[audio interlude]
Now you are credited as the arranger, the vocal arranger.

JS: Yes.

MR: Well how did you learn to do that?

JS: Okay. I'm amazed that you picked that tune and not like "Blues for Pablo" or "Four Brothers" or any of the other things I arranged. But I learned to do it with my ears, honestly. And I would have to give credit to listening to jazz a lot, instrumentalists mainly, and hearing those kinds of voicings, and learning to understand them and learning to ask questions when needed, and I did have help and mentors along the way. Jimmy Guiffre was one who taught me, when I was arranging "Four Brothers" I was going through some of the voices with him and he said, "how about a drop two voicing, when it goes [sings] 'four brothers' start in unison and then open up the voicing." And I said, "what does that mean?"

MR: And what did he say?

JS: Well he said you take the four part chord and drop the alto part an octave lower basically, and there's your drop two voicing. And I went, "oh my God, this opens up a whole nother world." And I did study privately with a man named Bob Bianco, who was a great, great teacher and wonderful influence. I studied privately with him out in Queens, the Schillinger System of Musical Composition.

MR: Oh my, I've heard that word a lot.

JS: Yeah. And Bob was teacher to Eddie Palmieri, to Michael Brecker, to Randy Brecker, and he also taught economics from his home. He was quite, quite a man, a really eccentric man, and I miss him deeply. Tim [Hauser] also studied with Bob. So that opened up the world of sigma and thirteenth chords, and I learned about permutations, permuting melody, permuting rhythms, it's very intellectual though. I found it very intellectual. But I never took like Theory 101 so I'm like there were major like holes in my musical education. But as far as like going back to our first album, "Manhattan

Transfer," I arranged "Candy," I arranged — what else did I arrange — oh "You Can Depend on Me" probably. But it was by ear.

MR: And how did you present the parts to your cohorts?

JS: In the beginning I wrote everybody's part out individually.

MR: Which must have been tedious, right.

JS: It was very tedious, very tedious. But I loved it and I did it, and then I learned to just put it on one piece of paper with everybody's part individually marked, but you could see the whole with the chords underneath. You could see every voicing.

MR: That helps the singers, doesn't it? To be able to see what everybody's doing?

JS: I think so. Especially as an inner part, I like to see it. That helps me learn actually. Because I'm visualizing the part in my mind, written usually, you know, if it's a really complex inner part.

MR: And the inner parts are usually harder to sing than the outer parts, aren't they?

JS: Well there's the melody, the melody, and the bass part usually mirrors the melody in some way or you sing roots or something. The tenor part I think is the worst.

MR: Wow. Okay so you write an arrangement and that moment that you first hear it back.

JS: Bliss on a stick. Oh yeah. It's amazing. And over the years of doing a lot of these arrangements, mainly for the Manhattan Transfer, I got to understand that what you put on paper doesn't necessarily translate to the voices. When you actually hear it being sung there still needs to be tweaking. Because it doesn't — I think piano players who arrange for voice have to understand that too. When you're singing words, and things have to make sense, and you have to breathe — because pianists don't have to breathe — that it takes a certain kind of pianist to arrange for voices. And when you write it down on paper, you need to hear it. Because there's inevitably some things that need to be tweaked.

MR: Were you writing the male parts in bass clef?

JS: Yes.

MR: Okay. So the look of it was true.

JS: Absolutely. As sounded.

MR: As sounded. Yeah.

JS: Yeah I would have brought you some vocal arrangements had I known.

MR: Yeah, you should hook up with some of the a cappella groups here. There's some great a cappella groups.

JS: That's another skill that's very specific. Writing for a cappella groups is different. Very different.

MR: Did you get into the business aspect of writing music that was going to be recorded? Did

JS: No. I look at it and I still look at it as my gift to the group.

MR: Nice. That's a good way to think of it.

JS: That's my contribution. I mean I have gotten paid. You know if we're doing a project for somebody else and I'm writing the arrangement then I'll ask for compensation. Or if I'm writing for somebody else, period, I'll ask for compensation. Or lately we've been trying to build in the budget a little stipend for the vocal arrangers. Because outside vocal arrangers get paid.

MR: Yeah. Is there a predetermined scale? A union scale?

JS: I don't think so. I wouldn't know. I don't know.

MR: Just a negotiation, huh?

JS: No I think it has to do with how complex it's going to be, whether it's a cappella or with a rhythm section, and, yeah, the complexity of the tune. How long it's going to take you to do it.

MR: Were you guys, this is probably a rhetorical question, were you excited when the T.V. thing came up on CBS?

JS: We were in shock actually. Because we were playing like little underground clubs, gay bars in San Francisco and New York, that kind of thing. And then all of a sudden we had a major television show on CBS at 7 o'clock on Sunday night. And also it was an opportunity for us to all move west. We all ended up moving west at that point, in '75. Because we had to be — we worked our asses off on that show. Because we had to sing arrangements. We had to prerecord the arrangements for the most part, except for the concert — we did concert sections for the live audience, where we sang live, like it was a show. But for the production numbers where we were dancing and stuff, we were in the studio also and so we ran out of repertoire after four weeks.

MR: Wow.

JS: It was a lot of work, but so much fun.

MR: So you were lip syncing. I was watching one, a lot of it's on YouTube now —

JS: We were lip syncing the production numbers.

MR: — a doo wop type number, and moving around a lot.

JS: Yeah.

MR: Was that the first time you had lip synced?

JS: I'm guessing it probably was. We had done some television before that. "CBS Sunday Morning" or something. That was pretty big. But it was our first experience probably with big time lip syncing, which is another art. I mean the trick is to really sing softly, so you look like you're actually breathing and — you know.

MR: Over the years I've seen some pretty bad —

MR: Can you remember what you got paid for that work?

JS: The T.V. show?

MR: Yeah.

JS: Oh my God. Yeah well I'm guessing we were on a salary then. It might have been $200 a week. I don't know. It was a blur. It was all a blur. Very early mornings. I mean I remember having to sit in the make-up chair for hours because they were marcelling my hair. Remember that or are you too young?

MR: Well I'm not too young but I don't know the term.

JS: Well it's from the 20s. It's that very — they used — actually at the time they used a hand-held curling iron that you had to heat up like on an anvil, like stone, and then it's a very tight curl. It's like a 20s look. And we were wearing wigs and we were wearing costumes and there were fittings and there was a lot to do. Learning lines, doing comedy routines, acting.

MR: Yeah. It was like a variety show.

JS: Well exactly right. It was a variety show. And we had comedians on every week. And one week we had the American television premier of Bob Marley and the Wailers. We did kinky reggae, awesome.

MR: Would anybody in the group have told the producer or the director like this is silly, we don't want to do this?

JS: Oh we said that all the time.

MR: Oh okay.

JS: Oh yeah. We said that all the time but it was hard to fight city hall. We had two sets of writers: our writers, who were a guy named Joel Silver, who ended up being one of the biggest producers in Hollywood. He did the Terminator movies. I mean he did some movies I know you would know.

MR: Okay.

JS: Joel Silver, who was just starting out; Fayette Hauser, who was Tim's sister and an original member of the Cockettes.

MR: The who? The Cockettes?

JS: Yes. The Cockettes were a legendary, groundbreaking sort of performance art music group in San Francisco of, let's say, gender-bending people, and very forward thinking. So Faye was on board. And Bruce Vilanch, who ended up writing for Bette Midler and for the Oscars, and a very big and funny man. So those were our writers. And then we had their writers, who were trying to keep it really stupid and dumb so that we would appeal to the middle of the country, which we never did. So that was that. We had some great dancers also.

MR: So we were talking about your first recording. ["The Hideaway" by The Young Generation.]

JS: Richard Perry. He was starting his own company at the time. He was just starting out too. He was from my neighborhood in Brooklyn. Dynamite Productions. And he was engaged to Linda Goldner, who was George Goldner's daughter. George Golder owned Red Bird Records. He was a very pivotal figure in the music business at the time. So our first record came out on Red Bird Records. And it was just a single deal. You had to sell a lot of singles to get an album deal in those days. It just didn't happen. And we sang on one microphone with a live orchestra. Artie Butler I think arranged that. Yes.

MR: Well, you know, it reminded me of "Crying in the Chapel" or something.

JS: Well exactly.

MR: That's the theme of it, yeah.

JS: That's the theme. Well Red Bird was the label of most of the girl groups. Shangri-Las, Reparata and the Delrons. You know, they had a lot of that.

MR: Yeah. What did your parents think of that? You have a record out.

JS: Yeah, I don't know if they really — none of our parents really were encouraging this too much. We were supposed to be going to college and becoming like professionals, and not musicians.

MR: I see.

JS: But that didn't really happen. And what actually — Dory, one of the girls on there, is a lawyer. She's already retired. And Rona went into computers or something or other.

MR: What would cause — you know someone said this to me the other day. I ran into a fellow musician and he said to me, "gee it's about time you retired, isn't it?" It sort of took me aback.

JS: I don't understand.

MR: Well what would cause you to retire?

JS: Nothing. It's not going to happen.

MR: Yeah. So when you do your solo records, do you find a producer or is a producer assigned to you or does it depend on the record label?

JS: I've always picked my own producers. Or I do it myself. Well I've learned to do it myself. It's not — I don't think it's a great idea actually, to produce yourself, to be honest. I mean I did it for the last record, but I find it's too much of a split. I want somebody in the booth listening, you know, and getting an overall objective picture and giving me feedback. I can certainly ask the right questions, but it's too much of a split. Because I'm trying to be in the booth and get — I'm trying to get lead vocals when the tracking is going down.

JS: So I'm busy singing and doing all that business. I can't be listening to hear if the bass player hit the wrong note or it needs —, or it's rushed — although I can feel that stuff while I'm singing but still it's better I think to have a producer. So yeah I've always picked my own producers. And when I was with a label, Telarc for instance, I would sort of think about what I wanted to do — I had to propose it to the record company and they would approve or not approve.

MR: And they give you a budget.

JS: Yeah.

MR: What happens if you go over budget?

JS: Then you're responsible for it.

MR: Out of your own pocket.

JS: Yeah.

MR: Okay. And that budget comes out of record sales first.

JS: Um um.

MR: How the heck do you keep track of money that's owed to you?

JS: It's not possible I don't think, unless you make a full time career out of it. I mean we're not — none of us are singer/songwriters really. So, although Alan's done a fair amount of writing, of vocalese writing and songwriting. Your publisher is supposed to be keeping track of that.

MR: And I think we had had this conversation when you were here before, about Spotify and all that kind of thing.

JS: Um hum.

MR: Anybody in the group is getting anything from that?

JS: Ut um.

MR: Does it aggravate you? Or is it not worth being aggravated about?

JS: I think it's not worth it, honestly. I have other things going on.

MR: Let me play another little thing for you here.

[audio interlude]

JS: He's the greatest

MR: You've had quite a productive relationship with Jon [Hendricks].

JS: Yes, I would say.

MR: How did you get connected?

JS: Well you know we've been doing his stuff from the very beginning honestly. And certainly we were aware of vocalese. For the first album Tim and I wrote a vocalese to "You Can Depend on Me" in the style — I mean influenced certainly by Lambert, Hendricks & Ross and Jon in particular. But we didn't really meet Jon and start a

to write the lyric. And Eddie was murdered tragically. And after a time went by we asked his widow if he had left anything behind in his papers, any start of a lyric or any — and she said no. So we called Jon and that was that. That was the beginning of a beautiful friendship. And he's very dear to us.

MR: Writing the arrangement, is it one of your favorites? The vocal?

JS: "Vocalese" you mean?

MR: No, I mean what was done with the vocals. Do you think it's one of Manhattan Transfer's best moments.

JS: Yes. Absolutely. I think "Vocalese" is something that we're very proud of, continuing the tradition of. And we did a whole record of vocalese with Jon and tackled some very meaty things. And Jon was able to tackle some meaty subjects in his lyrics, particularly "Joy Spring," "Airegin" really amazing lyrics. And he was in the video of "Rock House" and he was in the video of "Night in Tunisia." And whenever we could perform with Jon it's always a blessing.

MR: How is he doing these days?

JS: I think he's doing fine, I think for whatever, 93, 94. He's a little frail, a little frail and the last time I saw him I believe we had dinner. He's always a delightful dinner companion.

MR: He has a lot to say about a lot of subjects.

JS: And he's got a lot to say. He does.

MR: Okay. What makes a jazz singer a jazz singer?

JS: Well I think there's a few characteristics. I mean the jury is out as to whether improvisation is one of them. But it's a phrasing thing I think, and a sophistication that is one of the characteristics, I think, of a jazz singer. And there's a truth to it. It's a funny subject. I think a jazz singer would be one that is really more of a musician than just a singer. Because you have to be inside all of these chords, and understand what's going on, how the melody relates to the chord and the structure that's going by, how to play within it, and then a level of emotion that has to come through too I think. Although I think a lot of people find jazz intellectual. I never have. I always found that it moves me. Even stuff that was wildly intellectual, you know, like free jazz, and some of Coltrane's work too.

MR: Did you like his later period?

JS: Not as much as say "Coltrane Sound" and "A Love Supreme" and "Coltrane Plays the Blues." Although "Coltrane Sound" is one of my favorite records of his. And "A Love Supreme" was life-changing I'd say.

MR: How does a singer make it more likely that the instrumentalists are going to think of that singer as a musician?

JS: Well you have to be a musician. You have to know how to communicate with the instrumentalists, you have to know how to count off, you have to speak in the language of the musician. Not say, well just know how to talk about the structure of a tune and know what you want, and being able to direct without being bossy of course. But know how to — you have to know what you're doing for goodness sake. When you're tackling something like improvising or even just singing a standard, you have to come in knowing the melody. And you'd be surprised how many kids in high school and college level even come in to sing a song and they don't know the melody.

MR: Why would they say they know it?

JS: I don't know. Maybe they don't think it's important or they can make up their own or something. I don't know.

MR: Well how about the really just nitty gritty things of knowing your keys and having —

JS: Oh yeah, there's a whole list of things that you really should know before you get up on a bandstand.

MR: Give me a couple if you don't mind.

JS: Well you should know how to count off a tune, in the feel that you want [extraneous sound] see — ominous, in the time signature that you want, in the tempo that you want. One of the most horrible things I think you could ever do is if a tune starts and it's too slow, to turn around and start — that's not cool at all. I think you have to know how to end a tune. I mean there's different ways you could do it. You have to be ready for certain turnarounds that are very standard, and you have to be able to direct that. And then again, I mean if you're improvising you have to know the tune. You have to feel the changes coming by and be able to spontaneously compose something that is a story, not just quotes, but it's a difficult thing to do.

MR: Do you think they're teaching it in the New School and all that?

JS: I think that there are some schools and some teachers that are teaching it, teaching everything. Not just — you know Charlie Parker, one of the famous things he said, "if you don't live it it won't come out of your horn." Well I think that that should be taught a lot more in schools. Especially at Berklee, where it's just as important to live and to tell a story when you're playing, as it is to play the scales. Anyone can play the scales, really.

MR: That's right. What do you like from a piano accompanist, or don't like?

JS: I don't like someone who plays on top of what I'm singing. I mean the accompanist should know the melody and know the lyrics I think. I think that helps set the emotional tone of the tune. An accompanist should play around you and lead you, kind of like a current underneath. And I cite as some of the best examples Fred Hersch, John DiMartino, Alan Broadbent, Alan Pasqua, these are great accompanists. They should

do that. They'll set you up in some kind of wrong key, or that's why they really should know — it has to be someone who loves singers and loves songs.

MR: And loves being supportive I think.

JS: Yeah. Knows how to be supportive.

MR: You have to like that feeling, and get a joy out of it. How do you keep your voice healthy?

JS: Well I have an excellent teacher, because I've had problems before. I mean it's in your body – your instrument is in your body — so you're kind of — it sort of defines how you have to treat yourself I think. I mean there's no smoking. I mean I don't smoke. I used to smoke. I stopped smoking because I said to myself do I want to smoke or do I want to have my voice at age 70 or 75. So I stopped smoking. The voice does not like dryness, it doesn't like dust, it doesn't like to talk too loud, you have to be wary and aware of a crowded noisy space and how loud you're talking. You have to be careful that airplanes are just hotbeds of infection. So you have to keep the cords moist, warm. I warm up a half hour before I sing. I mean to me it's about technique: proper technique, breathing, cardiovascular work I do five times a week at least. And I sing with my whole body. And then there's the traveling. So I mean you have to have stamina for that as well. Singing requires a lot of stamina. It really does. And to me the goal is to have the technique developed to a point where I can have choices in how I want to sound. If I'm singing a Brazilian piece I can sing with a light, breathy tone with no vibrato if I want, but I can hold notes. And if I'm singing R&B I can belt more if I want and possibly do a little more frill. And if I'm singing a harmony part that also calls for no vibrato really. Because vibrato I think is the enemy of chords sounding. If you listen to the great vocal groups there isn't a lot of vibrato because the vibration changes the pitch and you have a mess if everybody's using vibrato. I think the less vibrato you have the purer the chord sound.

MR: Yeah. They say the same thing about a saxophone section.

JS: Well of course.

MR: Unless you want to be like Guy Lombardo.

JS: Yeah. And it's sweet and corny. The sweet sound.

MR: I wanted to throw out a name that you know, Joel Dorn?

JS: Yeah, he is one of the great ones. I sought him out. When I was about to do my first solo record for Atlantic in 1981 I gave some thought to it and I thought I'm just going to go through my collection and see who I like. And I picked out like Roberta Flack's record and Bette Midler's first record and there were some other things, and the Neville Brothers and then Freddie Hubbard and then this and that and this from Atlantic and I went I think Joel Dorn might be a good guy to talk to. So I made a cassette — that's how long ago it

eclectic and that's what he liked. And I had things by the Dixie Hummingbirds on there and I had vocalese and I had some pop things, and he liked that a lot.

MR: Was he affiliated with any record labels at the time?

JS: Atlantic.

MR: He was still at Atlantic.

JS: Yes. And that was a relationship that I treasured. And I think we were just becoming really good friends when he passed, I mean just gone. One day here, next day gone.

MR: Yeah, I learned of him sort of after the fact of records that I liked and then I started to see his name on this one and then Hubert Laws.

JS: Yes. Well Rahsaan Roland Kirk. He was the man.

MR: And Cannonball he loved.

JS: Yes.

MR: And Joe Williams he loved.

JS: And he loved Joe Williams. When Joe passed, he was friends with Joe's widow I believe and Joel gave me one of Joe's shirts, I think I told you that, which I still have at home.

MR: If I could write you a blank check —

JS: Yes please!

MR: To do whatever kind of project you wanted. A dream project. Do you have one?

JS: I could construct one if you give me like a half hour. I could. Oh yeah. There's musicians all over. I would do like a world music record I think, off the top of my head. There's a lot of musicians throughout the world that I really love, and I'm very curious about all the different styles there are. And I'd like to bring a little of myself into those styles. I mean that's what my Brazilian project is about. So I mean there's a Vietnamese guitarist that I love who lives in Paris. I can't pronounce his name — Nguyen Le — I'd love to work with him. I think his music is beautiful. And certainly some musicians from Africa and South America, the European jazz scene there's a lot of interesting players. Till Bronner is a German trumpet player whose music I really like. If I had one check, as you say, then I would probably go to these countries and just record there, and have fabulous meals while I'm there.

MR: It's funny you say that because you're a food blogger, right?

JS: Yeah.

MR: Are you a foodie?

JS: Yes, if you insist, I am.

MR: You had told me about some fellow who you cook with I think, last time you were here.

JS: Yeah. Well he's a friend and he's a professor at City College of New York at Sonic Arts. He's an engineer. And he was working on my little home studio putting it together and

wouldn't it be fun to construct a meal together. So we started doing that. It's hard to find time. And his wife bakes up a storm so we've got it all covered.

MR: Well just to wrap up, is there anything that pushes your buttons and makes you angry in particular?

JS: Messy dorm rooms, yes. Not being ready to be driven home.

MR: Musically.

JS: Angry? Well I mean it's a broad, broad question. I mean you know in my situation on the road I expect everyone to act professional. I don't like people that are constantly late for things.

MR: Constantly?

JS: Late. Don't show up on time. Yeah. I think it shows a disrespect and an entitlement.

MR: Well congratulations on your career.

JS: Thank you. The best is yet to come.

MR: Sounds like a song. Thanks a lot.

JS: Thank you, Monk.